At least a few of the reported incidents of temple destruction were formulaic or exaggerated, and may be only the most legible result of larger intentions.[7] It has been argued, for example, that Mahmud's infamous Somnath campaign of AH 415/1025 CE was much more than a raid to strip a temple of its riches: in reality, it was likely a failed attempt at coastal access for an otherwise land-locked empire; gaining entry into the Indian Ocean networks *via* the coast of Gujarat – the hinge linking the western and eastern halves of the Indian Ocean world – would have been a most profitable maritime debut.[8] Upon occupying Ghazna, then, Sultan Mu'izz al-Din came into a capital whose sovereigns had purported to be both Perso-Islamic as well as Indian kings (cf. Volume II).

Inheriting the geo-political momentum of Ghazna goes far in explaining the newly crowned Shansabani sultan's military sorties and campaigns, undertaken almost immediately upon conquering the Ghaznavid capital and its dependent areas. The greater facility in commanding large swaths of geography and climate – part of the "cultural capital" resulting from nomadic pastoralism and/or transhumance in lifestyle and ancestry (cf. Chapters 1, 2, and 5, above) – surely served as a continuing advantage for the sultan. Indeed, we saw in Chapter 1 that Mu'izz al-Din's very first campaign was to the physically and culturally remote region of Gujarat in AH 574/1178 CE, only four or five years after occupying Ghazna. This initial campaign becomes all the more remarkable when we recall that Mahmud himself had campaigned but once in Gujarat, and that only toward the end of his reign, with no other Ghaznavid sultan campaigning there again.[9] In this particular instance, the new Shansabani sultan of Ghazna might have overestimated the advantages afforded by his experience in nomadism and/or transhumance and its "cultural capital," and the concomitant apprehension of contiguous geographies and climates. But he was quick to recover and plot strategies that ultimately led to remarkable successes in India, which were extremely consequential for centuries to come (see Volume II).

Inherited Landscapes, Re-inscribed

The Ghaznavids, particularly the sultans Mahmud and Mas'ud I, had certainly crafted an imperial Perso-Islamic presence westward in Khurasan, but they had also blazed pathways eastward from the plains of Ghazna, leaving traces in the architectural–cultural zones of the western Indic world as they proceeded to the *duab* of northern India. The inertia of this economic and geo-political momentum, which Mu'izz al-Din maintained after his conquest of Ghazna, presented him with yet more inherited landscapes (cf. Chapters 1 and 2): a Perso-Islamic imperial "infrastructure" – consisting of royal or elite-patronized mosques and other public institutions – that